Google Business Profile Setup — United Methodist Church of Minot

Goal: Get the church to appear on Google Maps and in "church near me" searches, with correct hours, photos, and a link to umc-minot-maine.netlify.app. This is the single biggest step for local + AI-search discovery. It's **free** and takes about 30–45 minutes, plus a short wait for verification.

Your details (copy-paste these exactly)

Keep these **identical** everywhere you list the church online — Google rewards consistent Name / Address / Phone ("NAP").

Field	Value
Business name	United Methodist Church of Minot
Category (primary)	United Methodist church
Category (secondary)	Church
Address	142 Minot Ave, Minot, ME 04258
Map pin (lat, long)	44.0851445, -70.3191671
Phone	(207) 783-9097
Website	https://umc-minot-maine.netlify.app
Hours	Sunday 10:00 AM – 11:15 AM (worship service)
Email (for verification/contact)	minotumc@gmail.com

Before you start

- [ ] Use the **church's Google account** (`minotumc@gmail.com`) if it exists, not a personal one — this keeps ownership with the church. If there's no Google account for that address yet, create one first at https://accounts.google.com/signup.
- [ ] Be ready to receive **mail at the church address** — most churches verify by postcard.

Step-by-step

1. Go to the Business Profile manager

- Open **https://business.google.com** and sign in with the church Google account.
- Click **"Manage now"** / **"Add your business to Google."**

2. Search for the church first (it may already exist)

- Type **"United Methodist Church of Minot"** in the business-name box.
- **If it appears in the dropdown** (Google often auto-creates listings from map data), select it and click **"Claim this business"** — don't create a duplicate.
- **If it does not appear**, click **"Create a business with this name."**

3. Choose the business category

- Primary category: type **"United Methodist church"** and select it. (If unavailable, use **"Church"** or **"Place of worship."**)
- You can add a secondary category later from the dashboard.

4. Add the location (this is a place customers visit)

- When asked "Do you want to add a location customers can visit?" → **Yes**.
- Enter the address exactly: **142 Minot Ave, Minot, ME 04258**
- On the map step, **drag the pin** to the church building if it's slightly off. Your exact coordinates are **44.0851445, -70.3191671**.

5. Add contact info

- Phone: **(207) 783-9097**
- Website: **https://umc-minot-maine.netlify.app**

6. Verify the business

Google will offer one or more methods (which ones appear depend on the listing): - **Postcard (most common for churches):** Google mails a code to 142 Minot Ave. It takes ~5–14 days. When it arrives, log back in and enter the 5-digit code. **Don't edit the address while waiting** — it restarts the process. - **Phone / text / email:** if offered, faster — enter the code they send. - **Video verification:** if offered, you record a short video showing the building, signage, and interior. Follow the on-screen prompts. - ⏳ You can keep filling out the profile while verification is pending, but it won't show publicly until verified.

7. Complete the profile (do this while you wait, and after)

A "complete" profile ranks better and gives AI assistants more to cite: - [ ] **Hours:** add Sunday **10:00 AM – 11:15 AM**. Use "Special hours" for holidays (Christmas Eve, Easter sunrise, etc.). - [ ] **Description:** paste a short intro, e.g. *"A welcoming United Methodist congregation in Minot, Maine, gathering for Sunday worship at 10 AM. Open Hearts, Open Minds, Open Doors — all are welcome. Rooted in the community since 1835."* - [ ] **Photos** (biggest visual trust signal — aim for 5–10): building exterior, sanctuary interior, a fellowship/community photo, and the logo. You already have good ones in the site's `images/` folder. - [ ] **Services / attributes:** mark **wheelchair accessible entrance**, and any relevant attributes ("identifies as…", "welcoming" options if offered). - [ ] **From the business:** add the website link and set the church as "identifies as a place of worship" if prompted. - [ ] **Opening date:** you can set 1835 as the year established.

8. After it's verified

- [ ] **Post updates** occasionally (events, special services) via the "Add update" / "Posts" feature — active profiles rank higher.
- [ ] **Ask a few regular members to leave a Google review.** Reviews are a top ranking and trust factor. Even 5–10 honest reviews make a real difference for a small church.
- [ ] **Respond to reviews** (a short thank-you) — signals an active, cared-for listing.

After GBP: the next two off-site steps

1. **Google Search Console** — https://search.google.com/search-console Verify `umc-minot-maine.netlify.app` , submit `https://umc-minot-maine.netlify.app/sitemap.xml` , click "Request Indexing" on the homepage.
2. **Bing Webmaster Tools** — https://www.bing.com/webmasters Import from Search Console (feeds ChatGPT and Copilot search).

Quick troubleshooting

- **"This listing has already been claimed."** Someone (maybe a former staff/volunteer) owns it. Click **"Request access"** — Google emails the current owner; if no response in 7 days you can claim it.
- **Duplicate listings appear.** Claim the correct one and use the "Remove/report duplicate" option on the other so they don't compete.
- **Postcard never arrived.** After ~14 days, request a new code from the dashboard. Double- check the address had no typos and included nothing extra.
- **Name rules:** use the real church name only — don't stuff keywords like "Church Minot Maine Worship" into the name field; Google can suspend for that.